

ANCIENT HISTORY — PART 6

THE MAURYAN EMPIRE & POST-MAURYAN DYNASTIES

Chandragupta & Bindusara

Ashoka & Edicts

Administration

Shunga & Kanva

Satavahana

Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Kushans

Part 6 / 7 — Ancient History Series — SSC CGL / CHSL / CPO / MTS-GD

CGL READY PROMISE

Full lecture + notes content on the Mauryan Empire and the dynasties that followed it, with every PYQ-verified gap fact woven directly into its relevant topic below — no separate "extra facts" section.

1. Literary Sources for the Mauryan Period

Source	Author	Detail
Arthashastra	Kautilya (Chanakya/Vishnugupta)	Treatise on statecraft/administration; Kautilya was Chandragupta Maurya's Prime Minister/mentor
Indica	Megasthenes	Greek ambassador in Chandragupta's court, sent by Seleucus Nicator; describes society divided into 7 classes and claims no slavery existed (contradicted by Kautilya's own Arthashastra, which does mention slavery)
Mudrarakshasa	Vishakhadatta	Written during the Gupta period (later than the events it describes); describes how Chandragupta got Chanakya's help to overthrow the Nandas; also describes Chandragupta as belonging to a "lower clan"
Buddhist literature	—	Jataka Tales, Deepvansh/Mahavansh (Pali), Divyadana

ORIGIN OF THE MAURYAS — CONFLICTING TRADITIONS

Puranas: Mauryas belonged to **Shudras**. Mudrarakshasa: belonged to **Vrishala/Kulhina** (low clan). Junagadh Rock Inscription: belonged to **Vaishyas**. Treat as three separate, sometimes-contradictory traditions rather than one settled fact.

2. Chandragupta Maurya (322-297 BC)

Fact	Detail
Founder	Founded the Mauryan Empire, c. 322 BC, with Chanakya's help
Defeated	Dhana Nanda (last Nanda ruler); also defeated Seleucus Nicator (Alexander's commander, founder of the Seleucid Empire) and married his daughter Helena
Megasthenes	Sent to Chandragupta's court by Seleucus Nicator; wrote Indica
Later life	Adopted Jainism under Bhadrabahu; migrated to Shravanabelagola, Karnataka; died by Sallekhana (fasting unto death), c. 300 BC

3. Bindusara (297-273 BC)

Fact	Detail
Greek name	Amitrochates/Amitrakhades
Religious patronage	Patronised the Ajivika sect (founded by Makkhali Gosala)
Diplomatic exchange	Antiochus I (Syrian king) sent him gifts including sweet wine and dried figs, but declined to send a philosopher
Son	Ashoka

4. Ashoka the Great (269-232 BC)

Fact	Detail
Accession	Enthroned with the help of Radhagupta; ruled for ~37 years (coronation c. 269 BC, per some sources 4 years after his father's death)
Pre-accession role	Served as governor of Taxila and Ujjain before becoming king
Succession	Buddhist tradition claims he killed 99 brothers to ascend the throne, sparing only the youngest, Tissa
Kalinga War	Fought 8 years after his coronation, in 261 BC (some sources: 262-261 BC); described in the 13th Major Rock Edict
Change of heart	Deeply moved by the massacre; replaced Bherighosha (sound of war/physical conquest) with Dhammaghosha (sound of dharma/cultural conquest)
Titles	Called "Chanda Ashoka" (fierce Ashoka) before the Kalinga War; "Dhamma Ashoka" / Devanampiya Piyadassi ("beloved of the gods") after
Missionary work	Sent son Mahendra and daughter Sanghamitra to Ceylon (Sri Lanka) to spread Buddhism

Extent	Empire covered almost the entire subcontinent except the extreme south — including Afghanistan, Balochistan, Kashmir and Nepal valleys
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5. Ashokan Edicts

Type	Count	Detail
Major Rock Edicts	14	First deciphered in 1837 by James Prinsep , who noticed "Devanampiya Piyadassi" repeated across sites
Minor Rock Edicts	4 main ones (Maski, Gujjar, Brahmagiri, Nittur)	Confirmed the name "Ashoka" directly (unlike major edicts, which mostly use his titles)
Pillar Edicts	7	Delhi-Topra pillar is the only one with all 7 edicts; uses only one language (Prakrit) and one script (Brahmi)

Language	Script
Prakrit (most common)	Brahmi and Kharoshthi (introduced by Iranians)
Greek	Greek script
Aramaic	Aramaic script

Major Rock Edict	Content
I	Prohibits animal slaughter; bans festive gatherings
II	Medical care for humans and animals; mentions Chola, Pandya, Satyaputra and Chera kingdoms of South India, and Greek king Antiochus II
VII	Tolerance towards all religions and sects
VIII	Ashoka's first Dhamma Yatra to Bodh Gaya
XIII	Largest edict; describes the Kalinga War and Ashoka's remorse; mentions Dhamma victories over Greek kings Antiochus, Ptolemy, Magas, Antigonus, Alexander (of Epirus)
XIV	Describes engraving of inscriptions across the country

DIRECT PYQ FACTS
"As per the contents in Ashokan inscriptions, how many major political centres were there in the Mauryan Empire?" (SSC MTS 16/05/2023 Morning) → **Five** — the central province (Pataliputra) plus the four provincial capitals: Taxila (Uttarapatha/North), Ujjain (Avantipatha/West), Tosali (Prachyapatha/East, in Kalinga), Suvarnagiri (Dakshinapatha/South). "Which of the following is NOT one of the broad categories of Ashokan edicts?" → **Personal epistles directed to the Sangha** is the correct "not included" answer (the genuine categories are: edicts for propagation of dhamma, public pronouncements for subjects, and philosophy/relevance explanations).

6. Pillars, Caves & National Emblem

Object	Detail
Pillar structure	Shaft → Inverted lotus → Abacus → Capital
Sarnath Lion Capital	4 lions; wheel on the abacus; commemorates Buddha's first sermon; declared India's National Emblem on 24 January 1950
Rampurva Bull	Only a bull found, no lions; kept at Rashtrapati Bhavan
Barabar Hill Caves, Lomas Rishi Caves	Bihar; built by Ashoka for Ajivikas/Buddhists
Nagarjuni Caves	Bihar; built by Dasharatha Maurya , Ashoka's grandson
Assembly of 80 pillars ruins	Associated with Kumrahar, Pataliputra — Mauryan-era assembly hall remains

7. Mauryan Administration

Concept	Detail
Saptanga theory (Kautilya)	7 elements of a state: King (Raja), Secretary/Minister (Amatya), Territory (Janapada), Fort (Durga), Treasury (Kosha), Army (Sena), Ally (Mitra)
Sannidhata	Chief Treasury Officer
Samaharta/Samharata	Collector General of Revenue
Akshapatalika	Audit officer
Sitadhyaksha	In charge of agriculture
Gopa	Responsible for accounts
Dhamma Mahamatta	New post created by Ashoka; checked whether people were following Dhamma

Koshadhyaksha	Treasury officer (distinct from Sannidhata in some listings)
Lakshanadhyaksha	Officer in charge of coin minting
Rajjuka	Land-measurement officer
Yukta	Subordinate officer, assisted senior officials in provincial administration
Shulkadhyaksha	Officer-in-charge of toll tax/royal income

Courts	Function
Dharmasthiya Nyayalaya	Personal/civil disputes
Kantakashodhana Nyayalaya	State-related/criminal cases

Provinces	Capital	Direction
Uttarapatha	Taxila	North
Avantipatha	Ujjain	West
Prachyapatha	Toshali/Kalinga	East
Dakshinapatha	Suvarnagiri	South
Central	Pataliputra (Magadha)	—

Economy	Detail
Ports	West: Bharuch, Supara; East: Tamralipti
Taxes	Ashoka reduced tax burdens; Bali (voluntary offering) was not compulsory under him
Municipal admin (per Megasthenes)	6 committees, 5 members each; Army similarly organised into 6 committees of 5 members each

DIRECT PYQ CONTRAST

Kautilya's Arthashastra explicitly states that governance **cannot be the work of one man** — the Mauryas built an elaborate multi-officer administrative system. The **Shungas** (Mauryas' political successors) did **not** continue this same elaborate administrative policy — a contrast tested directly in Assertion-Reason format questions.

8. Decline of the Mauryan Empire

Ruler	Detail
Successors after Ashoka	Weaker rulers followed, including Dasharatha Maurya (built Nagarjuni caves)
Brihadratha	Last Mauryan ruler; ruled 187–180 BC; predecessor was Shatadhanvan (195–187 BC); assassinated by his own general, Pushyamitra Shunga , who founded the Shunga dynasty

9. Shunga Dynasty (185–73 BC)

Fact	Detail
Founder	Pushyamitra Shunga — assassinated Brihadratha in 185/187 BC
Capital	Vidisha (Madhya Pradesh)
Religion	Followed Hinduism; also patronised Buddhism — Bharhut Stupa built under his reign
Son	Agnimitra — hero of Kalidasa's play <i>Malavikagnimitra</i>
Patanjali	Wrote Mahabhasya; performed two Ashwamedha Yagyas for Pushyamitra
Last ruler	Devbhuti — killed by his commander Vasudev Kanva , leading to the Kanva Dynasty (73–28 BC), capital Pataliputra

10. Satavahana Dynasty (60 BC–225 AD)

Fact	Detail
Region	Deccan region — present-day Maharashtra, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh
Capital	Paithan/Pratishthan (Maharashtra)
Founder	Simuka Satavahana
Also known as	Andhra/Andhrabhritya
Greatest ruler	Gautamiputra Satakarni — defeated the Shaka ruler Kshatrapa Nahapana; restored Satavahana power
Matronymics	Satavahana rulers used the mother's name alongside their own (e.g. "Gautamiputra" = son of Gautami) — a distinctive naming feature, reflecting importance of maternal lineage within an otherwise patriarchal society; also described as a mixed patriarchal-matrilineal social structure

Nasik Inscription	Composed by Gautamiputra Satakarni's mother, Gautami Balashri, after his death
Coinage	First to issue lead coins; also used potin (base silver); copper coins bearing the Ujjain symbol (a ship) were common in Avanti
Religion	Embraced Brahmanism/took the title of "Brahmin," but also patronised other religions
King Hala	Compiled the Prakrit poetry text Gatha Saptashati
Script	Brahmi; language Prakrit
Architecture	Chaityas/Viharas at Kanheri, Karle, Nasik caves (Maharashtra); early work at Ajanta caves; stupas at Amravati and Nagarjunakonda (Andhra Pradesh)

11. Invasions from Central Asia — Overview

Sequence: **Indo-Greeks → Shakas (Scythians) → Parthians → Kushans** — mainly due to pressure from the Great Wall of China pushing Central Asian tribes westward/southward.

Indo-Greeks

Fact	Detail
Greatest ruler	Milind/Menander — converted to Buddhism after dialogue with monk Nagasena, recorded in <i>Milinda Panho</i>
Art	Introduced Hellenistic (Greek) art style, later seen in Gandhara School of Art
Coinage	First to introduce gold coins in India, and portrait coins ("attributed to kings" — the king's image on the coin)
Numbers	Over 40 Indo-Greek rulers are known primarily from their coins

Shakas (Scythians)

Fact	Detail
Branches	5 branches total; one branch settled in the Gujarat/western India region, ruling until c. 4th century AD
Famous ruler	Rudradaman I (c. 130–150 AD); described in the Junagadh Rock Inscription (Girnar, Gujarat)
Sudarshan Lake	Originally built by Pushyagupta Vaishya (under Chandragupta Maurya); repaired by Rudradaman I (and later again by Skandagupta)
Defeat	Defeated by Vikramaditya (of Ujjain), who started the Vikram Samvat era in 57 BC — this is a legendary/traditional account, not officially followed by the Government of India
Administrative system	Introduced the Satrap system of government (provincial governors) — borrowed from the earlier Greek "Strategos" concept; used specifically by Shaka/Western Kshatrapa rulers

Kushans (1st-3rd century AD)

Fact	Detail
Also known as	Yuezhi/Tocharians — originally a Central Asian tribe
Capitals	Purushapura (Peshawar) — first capital; later also Mathura
Self-title	"Sons of God" / "King of Kings" (Devaputra) — reflecting supreme political authority over subordinate rulers
Dynasty sequence	Kujula Kadphises (founder, united the Yuezhi tribes) → Vima Kadphises → Kanishka (most powerful ruler)
Kanishka's accession	78 AD — this date marks the start of the Shaka Era (Saka calendar), still used by the Government of India
Kanishka's court	Physician Charaka ; surgeon Sushruta ; poet/scholar Ashvaghosha (author of Buddhacharita), brought to Purushapura
Buddhist patronage	Patronised the Fourth Buddhist Council at Kundalvan, Kashmir; supported Mahayana Buddhism ; called "the second Ashoka"
Coinage	Introduced the purest form of gold coins in ancient India (though the Guptas later issued gold coins in the largest overall quantity)
Trade	Controlled a section of the Silk Route, facilitating cultural exchange and the spread of Mahayana Buddhism to Central Asia and China
Language of inscriptions	Bactrian, written in Greek script — reflecting Central Asian origins, alongside some Sanskrit usage
Impact on society	Fully assimilated into Indian culture; introduced horsemanship techniques, turban and long-coat (Sherwani-style) clothing; used Red Ware pottery
Later rulers	Vasishka, Huvishka, Vasudeva

12. Master Revision — Learn These First

Trigger	Answer
Author of Arthashastra	Kautilya (Chanakya)

Author of Indica	Megasthenes
Author of Mudrarakshasa (written in Gupta period)	Vishakhadatta
Founder of Maurya dynasty	Chandragupta Maurya, 322 BC
Chandragupta defeated	Dhana Nanda; Seleucus Nicator
Bindusara's Greek name	Amitrochates
Bindusara's religion	Patronised Ajivikas
Ashoka's governorships before kingship	Taxila and Ujjain
Ashoka spared this brother	Tissa (youngest, per Buddhist tradition)
Kalinga War year	261 BC
Bherighosha replaced by	Dhammaghosha
Ashoka's children sent to Ceylon	Mahendra and Sanghamitra
Major Rock Edicts count / decipherer	14 / James Prinsep (1837)
Number of major political centres in Mauryan Empire	Five (Pataliputra + 4 provincial capitals)
NOT a category of Ashokan edicts	Personal epistles to the Sangha
National Emblem source	Sarnath Lion Capital, adopted 24 January 1950
Nagarjuni Caves built by	Dasharatha Maurya
Saptanga theory — 7 elements	Raja, Amatya, Janapada, Durga, Kosha, Sena, Mitra
Last Mauryan ruler	Brihadratha — killed by Pushyamitra Shunga
Shunga capital	Vidisha
Shunga dynasty ended by	Vasudev Kanva (killed Devbhuti)
Satavahana founder	Simuka Satavahana; capital Paithan
Greatest Satavahana ruler	Gautamiputra Satakarni — defeated Shaka ruler Nahapana
Satavahana naming pattern	Matronymics (mother's name attached)
Satavahana coinage first	Lead coins
King who compiled Gatha Saptashati	Hala (Satavahana)
Greatest Indo-Greek ruler	Milind/Menander — converted to Buddhism (Milinda Panho)
First to introduce gold coins in India	Indo-Greeks
Famous Shaka ruler + inscription	Rudradaman I; Junagadh Rock Inscription
Sudarshan Lake — built by / repaired by	Built: Pushyagupta Vaishya; Repaired: Rudradaman I
Vikram Samvat started by	Vikramaditya, 57 BC (traditional, not govt.-followed)
Provincial governance system introduced by Shakas	Satrap system
Kushan founder	Kujula Kadphises
Most powerful Kushan ruler	Kanishka; accession 78 AD; started Shaka Era
Kanishka's court physicians	Charaka, Sushruta
Kanishka's Buddhist council	Fourth, at Kundalvan, Kashmir
Kushan capitals	Purushapura (Peshawar), Mathura
Kushan title	"King of Kings" / Devaputra

13. PYQ-Style Question Bank

- Q1.** Who wrote the Arthashastra? **Ans:** Kautilya (Chanakya/Vishnugupta).
- Q2.** Who wrote Indica, and in whose court was he present? **Ans:** Megasthenes; Chandragupta Maurya's court.
- Q3.** Who wrote Mudrarakshasa, and in which period? **Ans:** Vishakhadatta; written during the Gupta period.
- Q4.** Whom did Chandragupta Maurya defeat to found his empire? **Ans:** Dhana Nanda and Seleucus Nicator.
- Q5.** What sect did Bindusara patronise? **Ans:** Ajivika sect.
- Q6.** Which two regions did Ashoka govern before becoming king? **Ans:** Taxila and Ujjain.
- Q7.** Which brother did Ashoka spare, according to Buddhist tradition? **Ans:** Tissa.
- Q8.** In which year was the Kalinga War fought? **Ans:** 261 BC.
- Q9.** What did Ashoka replace Bherighosha with, after the Kalinga War? **Ans:** Dhammaghosha.
- Q10.** Who deciphered the Ashokan Major Rock Edicts, and when? **Ans:** James Prinsep, 1837.
- Q11.** How many major political centres did the Mauryan Empire have per the inscriptions? **Ans:** Five.
- Q12.** Which is NOT a category of Ashokan edicts? **Ans:** Personal epistles directed to the Sangha.

- Q13.** When was the Sarnath Lion Capital adopted as India's National Emblem? **Ans:** 24 January 1950.
- Q14.** Who built the Nagarjuni Caves? **Ans:** Dasharatha Maurya.
- Q15.** Name the seven elements of Kautilya's Saptanga theory. **Ans:** Raja, Amatya, Janapada, Durga, Kosha, Sena, Mitra.
- Q16.** Who was the last ruler of the Mauryan dynasty, and who killed him? **Ans:** Brihadratha; killed by Pushyamitra Shunga.
- Q17.** What was the capital of the Shunga dynasty? **Ans:** Vidisha.
- Q18.** Who ended the Shunga dynasty? **Ans:** Vasudev Kanva (killed Devbhuti).
- Q19.** Who founded the Satavahana dynasty, and what was its capital? **Ans:** Simuka Satavahana; capital Paithan.
- Q20.** Who was the greatest Satavahana ruler, and whom did he defeat? **Ans:** Gautamiputra Satakarni; defeated Shaka ruler Nahapana.
- Q21.** What naming pattern did Satavahana rulers follow? **Ans:** Matronymics (mother's name).
- Q22.** Which metal coins did the Satavahanas first issue? **Ans:** Lead coins.
- Q23.** Who compiled the Gatha Saptashati? **Ans:** King Hala (Satavahana).
- Q24.** Who was the greatest Indo-Greek ruler, and what happened to him? **Ans:** Milind/Menander; converted to Buddhism.
- Q25.** Who introduced gold coins in India for the first time? **Ans:** The Indo-Greeks.
- Q26.** Which inscription describes Shaka ruler Rudradaman I? **Ans:** Junagadh Rock Inscription.
- Q27.** Who built the Sudarshan Lake, and who repaired it? **Ans:** Built by Pushyagupta Vaishya; repaired by Rudradaman I.
- Q28.** Who started the Vikram Samvat, and when? **Ans:** Vikramaditya, 57 BC.
- Q29.** What administrative system did the Shakas introduce? **Ans:** Satrap system (provincial governors).
- Q30.** Who founded the Kushan Empire? **Ans:** Kujula Kadphises.
- Q31.** Who was the most powerful Kushan ruler, and when did he accede to the throne? **Ans:** Kanishka; 78 AD.
- Q32.** What era did Kanishka's accession mark the start of? **Ans:** The Shaka Era.
- Q33.** Who were the famous physicians at Kanishka's court? **Ans:** Charaka and Sushruta.
- Q34.** Which Buddhist Council did Kanishka patronise, and where? **Ans:** Fourth Buddhist Council, at Kundalvan, Kashmir.
- Q35.** What were the Kushan capitals? **Ans:** Purushapura (Peshawar) and Mathura.

14. Last-Minute One-Page Revision

THE ENTIRE PART IN ONE FLOW

CHANDRAGUPTA MAURYA (founds empire, 322 BC, with Chanakya) → BINDUSARA (Ajivika patron) → ASHOKA (Kalinga War 261 BC → Dhamma over Bheri; 14 Major + 4 Minor Rock Edicts + 7 Pillar Edicts; Saptanga administration) → DECLINE (Brihadratha killed by Pushyamitra Shunga) → SHUNGA (Vidisha; ends with Kanva dynasty) → SATAVAHANA (Deccan; Gautamiputra Satakarni; matronymics; lead coins) → CENTRAL ASIAN INVASIONS: Indo-Greeks (gold coins, Milind) → Shakas (Satrap system, Rudradaman) → Kushans (Kanishka, Shaka Era 78 AD, 4th Buddhist Council) → feeds directly into the Gupta Empire (Part 7).